Case Study Report: Responsible Citizens

Course: Digital Literacy

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Section A: Establish the Context

To a classmate who uses Canva, collaborates on Google Docs, and maintains a LinkedIn profile, I'd describe the situation in this case study not as a story of failure, but as a mirror reflecting our own digital habits. The case follows a student named Arjun, who, like many of us, is digitally active. He uses tools efficiently, builds an online presence, and collaborates with peers. From the outside, he appears digitally competent. However, a closer look reveals a significant gap: he is using tools without truly understanding their impact.

The underlying gap is between digital participation and true digital literacy. Arjun knows how to use a tool but doesn't always reflect on why he uses it a certain way or what the consequences might be. For instance, he can create a GitHub repository but doesn't grasp the ethical implications of uploading incomplete or copied code. He can send an email but doesn't appreciate how his tone shapes a professor's perception of him. This gap is significant because it creates a dangerous illusion of competence. We believe we are ready for the professional world because we can navigate its platforms, but we are often unprepared for its expectations regarding ethics, accountability, and professionalism.

The widespread availability of user-friendly platforms has directly created this illusion. Tools like Canva, with their drag-and-drop templates, or Google Docs, with their real-time collaboration, are designed to make tasks easier. They lower the barrier to entry, allowing anyone to produce a polished output. This convenience is a double-edged sword. It makes us mistake the ability to create a visually appealing presentation for the ability to construct a well-researched, accurate argument. We start valuing the tool's output over our own intellectual input. As the case study points out, we become "consumers of digital convenience rather than critical thinkers."

Finally, this case reveals the critical difference between participation and literacy. Digital participation is the act of being online: creating a profile, posting content, and using apps. It’s about presence. Digital literacy, as defined by this case, goes far beyond that. It encompasses understanding impact (how a GIF might be perceived in a formal setting), responsibility (ensuring individual contribution in a group project), and risk (recognizing a phishing attempt). Arjun was a participant, but he lacked the deeper literacy to navigate the complexities of his digital life. The case matters because it challenges the assumption that being a "digital native" automatically makes one a "digital citizen."

Section B: Digital Identity and Ethics

Position: Building a digital presence offers significant benefits, but these are currently overshadowed for many students by the substantial and underestimated risks associated with performance-driven inauthenticity. The problem is not the platforms themselves, but how we, as students, are conditioned to use them.

Argument: The Promise vs. The Reality of Equal Opportunity

The ideal that platforms like LinkedIn and GitHub democratize opportunity is compelling. They theoretically allow a student from a small college to showcase their projects to a global employer, bypassing traditional gatekeepers. This is a powerful and, in many cases, a genuine benefit. However, the case study’s reality check on Arjun’s profiles shows that this ideal is often undermined by practice. The opportunity to showcase skills becomes an opportunity to curate a false reality. Instead of leveling the playing field based on skill, these platforms can level it based on who is best at marketing themselves, not who has the deepest understanding. The "equal

opportunity" is only as good as the honesty of the person presenting it.

Performance Over Authenticity

The case argues that platforms encourage performance over authenticity. I strongly agree. The architecture of these platforms—with their endorsements, follower counts, and contribution graphs—turns personal development into a public competition. Students feel immense pressure to appear "prolific" and "skilled," leading them to prioritize visibility over genuine competence. Arjun listing skills he "briefly explored" is a common example. We are incentivized to look good now rather than to be good later. The focus shifts from the long-term goal of learning to the short-term goal of getting likes, connections, or recruiter attention.

The Ethics of Misrepresentation

The question of whether exaggerating skills is ethically wrong or an accepted norm is where I take a firm stance: it is unequivocally ethically wrong. The "everyone does it" defense is a rationalization for dishonest behavior, not a valid ethical framework. While I understand the competitive environment, this does not make misrepresentation acceptable. Presenting incomplete or copied code on GitHub is not just exaggeration; it’s a form of intellectual dishonesty that devalues the platform for everyone. It erodes trust, which is the foundation of any professional community. When we exaggerate, we are not just lying to potential employers; we are lying to ourselves, trading genuine self-improvement for a hollow, temporary advantage.

Digital Permanence and Accountability

The concept of digital permanence is perhaps the most uncomfortable. Should we be held accountable for everything we post, even from a time when we "lacked awareness"? My position is yes, but with context. The digital record is permanent, and we cannot expect the world to ignore it. However, accountability should not be blind. There is a difference between a foolish teenage post and a pattern of professional dishonesty. A recruiter should hold a student accountable for an inflated LinkedIn profile submitted as part of a job application today. But to judge a person harshly for a single, naive comment they made years ago, without considering their growth, is an overly punitive application of digital permanence. The responsibility, therefore, falls on the student to be aware that their past can be discovered, but it also calls for a more nuanced, human approach from those evaluating them. The ultimate ethical position is to conduct oneself online from the start with the awareness that everything is permanent.

Section C: Collaboration vs. Misuse

Digital collaboration platforms are a powerful, yet potentially problematic, force in modern learning. They are like fire: they can cook your food or burn your house down depending on how you use them. My evaluation is that their design significantly enables dependency and shortcuts unless counterbalanced by strong pedagogical structures and individual accountability.

On one hand, platforms like Google Docs are fantastic for coordination. They allow groups to work asynchronously, see each other's contributions, and build on ideas efficiently. This can lead to richer outputs than traditional, siloed work. However, the case study of Arjun's group reveals the dark side: they enable the "illusion of collaboration." Unequal participation becomes invisible. A student can copy-paste slides, make a few formatting changes, and appear to have contributed equally. The platform does not differentiate between

the student who wrote the core argument and the one who just changed the font. In this way, the platform itself reduces accountability.

The boundary between collaboration and academic dishonesty is inherently ambiguous. Working together to understand a concept is collaboration. Dividing a project into parts and assembling them is efficient project management. But when does "sharing ideas" become "sharing answers"? If a student in a coding group doesn't understand the code they are submitting, is that collaboration or enabling dishonesty? The line is often blurred because digital tools make copying and sharing seamless. The boundary is not just ambiguous; it's movable. It requires constant judgment, which is precisely the skill that is not being developed when students default to efficiency.

The reduction of visibility of individual effort does make ethical behavior harder to enforce. If a professor can only see the final polished document, they cannot see the process of its creation. The "why" behind a student's lack of understanding is hidden. This doesn't mean students are inherently unethical, but the environment removes the natural deterrents against free-riding. It requires a level of self-enforced ethics that is more mature than what many students, still learning, possess.

The Strongest Argument for Digital Collaboration:

The strongest argument for unrestricted digital collaboration is that it mirrors the real world. In a professional setting, teams use shared workspaces, version control (like Git), and collaborative documents daily. The goal is a successful product, not an equitable distribution of learning. Restricting these tools in education would be like teaching someone to swim without water. The "real world" cares about the final output and the team's ability to work together efficiently, not about who contributed how many lines of code. Therefore, educational collaboration should be unrestricted to best prepare students for their future careers.

Why I Disagree (or rather, qualify this argument):

While I agree that the professional world values output, I argue that education has a different primary goal: learning. In a corporate setting, if a junior developer doesn't understand the code a senior wrote, the company may still succeed. In education, if a student passes a course without understanding the material, the student fails. Therefore, unrestricted collaboration without safeguards is pedagogically flawed. We need to find a middle ground. The solution is not to ban collaboration, but to design assignments that make individual accountability a core part of the process. This could involve using the "version history" feature to track contributions, incorporating individual follow-up questions (as the case study's professor did), or requiring students to document their process. The platform itself can be used to enforce accountability, but we must move beyond assuming that "collaboration" is inherently good for learning.

Section D: Cyber Awareness and Responsibility

Cybercrimes like phishing succeed despite awareness campaigns because they exploit human psychology, not just technical ignorance. The case of Arjun falling for a phishing email is a textbook example of this. He knew about phishing, but the attacker bypassed his knowledge by exploiting his desire for an opportunity and creating a sense of urgency. Awareness campaigns are good at teaching us what to look for (e.g., a suspicious link), but they are less effective at overriding the instinct to click when we see a promising opportunity. The success of these attacks lies in their ability to manipulate emotion—fear, greed, excitement—into overriding logic.

This brings us to the complex question of responsibility. The user is ultimately responsible for their own actions; they click the link , they enter the password. There is a baseline expectation of caution.

However, to place the blame solely on the user ignores the sophisticated design of both legitimate platforms and malicious actors. Platforms are designed to encourage quick, seamless interactions, which is exactly the behavior attackers' exploit. A platform could do more to warn users of suspicious senders, make "urgent" emails stand out as a risk, or implement more robust verification processes for official communications. Institutions also bear responsibility. A one-time cyber awareness lecture in the first year is clearly insufficient. The case study shows that knowledge degrades under pressure. Therefore, responsibility is shared: users must cultivate habitual caution, while platforms and institutions must design for safety and provide continuous, practical training.

Consider a student falling victim to a scam. Is this negligence, lack of education, or systemic failure? It is a combination of all three, but the dominant factor is systemic failure of education to adapt to behavioural psychology. Calling it mere "negligence" is too harsh and victim-blaming. It assumes a level of constant, rational vigilance that is unrealistic. Calling it a "lack of education" is also incomplete, as Arjun had the education. The systemic failure is in assuming that knowledge equals behavior. Our current preventive measures (passwords, annual training, standard guidelines) are necessary but not sufficient. They fail to address the deeper behavioural issues—the human tendency to trust, to want to believe in good news, and to act quickly when under pressure.

To be effective, preventive measures need to evolve from "telling students what not to do" to "training them how to act." This means moving beyond passive lectures to active simulations, such as sending mock phishing emails to the student body to create a culture of healthy scepticisms. It also requires integrating cyber awareness into every digital interaction, not treating it as a separate, one-time topic. Until our approach to cyber safety changes from a lesson to a habit, the gap between awareness and action will persist.

Section E: Communication and Digital Etiquette

Students often fail to maintain professionalism in emails because of a conflict between our dominant communication habits and the context of a formal interaction. Our daily digital lives are built on instant messaging platforms like WhatsApp, Discord, or Instagram, where communication is characterized by speed, informality, abbreviations, and a low expectation of permanence. This style becomes our automatic, default mode. When we switch to a professional context—like emailing a professor—we often do so in a hurry, and our deeply ingrained habit of casual, efficient communication takes over. We know the rules of professional etiquette, but under pressure and in a rush, habit overrides awareness.

The question of whether informal communication is "becoming the norm" is a fascinating one. In many tech-forward industries, a certain level of informality (e.g., using first names, slack channels) is indeed the norm. However, I believe this is a surface-level change. The core principles of respect, clarity, and consideration have not disappeared. An overly casual tone that works in a Slack channel with your manager can be perceived as disrespectful in an email to a client. The evolution is not a blanket permission to be informal everywhere; it's a contextual shift. The problem is when students, like Arjun, fail to recognize the shift in context.

Individuals should absolutely be judged on their digital communication style, as it is a direct reflection of their professionalism, attention to detail, and respect for the recipient. An email is a proxy for the person. A message like Arjun's original email—"i sir, I need recommendations urgently. Send asap."—conveys a sense of carelessness, entitlement, and a lack of basic courtesy. Even if his intentions were good, the communication style created a negative impression that he had to overcome. In a competitive environment for internships or jobs, where first impressions are critical, such a misstep can have significant consequences. It signals to a potential employer that the individual might be similarly careless with client communications or internal reports. Therefore, mastering professional digital communication is

not an archaic skill but a fundamental component of a professional identity.

Section F: Reflection

Before engaging with this case study, my definition of "digital literacy" was quite shallow. I thought it meant being comfortable with technology—knowing how to code a bit, using Google Suite, creating presentations, and having a decent social media presence. I prided myself on being a "digital native." Arjun felt uncomfortably familiar to me.

My understanding has fundamentally changed. I now see digital literacy as a much deeper, more critical skill. It's not about the tools I can use, but the quality of decisions I make while using them. It's about being aware of my digital footprint, the ethics of my online profiles, the responsibility I hold in a collaborative group, and the ability to communicate with intent rather than just habit.

What surprised me most was how the case study connected seemingly minor, everyday actions to significant consequences. The email incident, in particular, made me uncomfortable because I've probably sent similar, rushed messages. I realized I have been operating on autopilot, treating all digital spaces as informal and not respecting the boundaries between personal and professional communication. It made me view my own digital habits with a new, more critical eye.

I don't believe I am using digital platforms as responsibly as I could be. My LinkedIn profile, for instance, lists skills that I have only a surface-level knowledge of. I've contributed to group projects where my role was minimal, yet I shared the credit equally. I've also clicked on links in emails without verifying the source because the opportunity looked exciting. This case study has been a much-needed